

to add smilies or change the font colour or strength easily. GT keeps things pretty austere. You can also send text messages to a friend who is using the Standard with Chat version of Gmail—the message will pop up in his browser.

To start a Voice chat, click on the Call button. After you press Call, you'll be able to talk (assuming you've set up your headset properly) as well as text-chat. You'll notice three buttons: "Email," "End Call," and "Mute." The e-mail button is, of course, meant for quickly sending over an e-mail, though we're wondering who'd do that while chatting. One useful feature is that the microphone and output sound levels are controllable via sliders right in the chat window. Use them to set the appropriate levels if you didn't already do it before you began the chat session.

If a person is offline, you can either send him a text message or record a voice message that will be played when he logs in the next time. An e-mail is sent to the person's Gmail Inbox containing the message. If it is a text message, the text is provided; in case of voice messages, the message title contains the length of the message, and it can be heard online or downloaded as an MP3.

10.6.3 Configuring Google Talk

The controls are much simpler and easy to access since there are no three-level-deep menu systems to navigate. The Sole link on the interface, besides the View and Add Contacts buttons, is the Settings link, which can be used to configure GT. There are significantly fewer options to be tweaked when compared to other IM clients. Cosmetic changes like skins and themes, and changing font styles and strength, can be done through the Settings link. The headphone and mic settings for voice chat can also be set here. By default, a history of your chats is stored in your Gmail account. This can be disabled.

10.6.4 Concluding Remarks

Google Talk comes across as an application built with a single purpose. The biggest drawback is the lack of video/webcam support. So far, Google has not allowed cross-client conversation like Yahoo! and